

Johnson, and the company still faced further FDA review on the new claims.

In another case, which happened about the same time, investors did better homework. A new medical study reported that an aspirin every other day might reduce the risk of men's getting heart attacks. The study used the Bufferin brand of aspirin made by Bristol-Myers, but Bristol-Myers stock hardly budged, moving up just 50 cents per share to \$42<sup>7</sup>/<sub>8</sub>. A lot of people must have realized that domestic Bufferin sales last year were \$75 million, less than 1.5 percent of Bristol-Myers's total revenues of \$5.3 billion.

A somewhat better aspirin play was Sterling Drug, maker of Bayer aspirin, before it was bought out by Eastman Kodak. Sterling's aspirin sales were 6.5 percent of its total revenues, but close to 15 percent of the company's profits— aspirin was Sterling's most profitable product.

## **BIG COMPANIES, SMALL MOVES**

The size of a company has a great deal to do with what you can expect to get out of the stock. How big is this company in which you've taken an interest? Specific products aside, big companies don't have big stock moves. In certain markets they perform well, but you'll get your biggest moves in smaller companies. You don't buy stock in a giant such as Coca-Cola expecting to quadruple your money in two years. If you buy Coca-Cola at the right price, you might triple your money in six years, but you're not going to hit the jackpot in two.

There's nothing wrong with Procter and Gamble or Coca-Cola, and recently both have been excellent performers. But you just have to know these are big companies so you won't have false hopes or unrealistic expectations.

Sometimes a series of misfortunes will drive a big company into desperate straits, and, as it recovers, the stock will make a big move. Chrysler had a big move, as did Ford and Bethlehem Steel. When Burlington Northern got depressed, the stock dropped from \$12 to \$6 and then climbed back to \$70. But these are extraordinary situations that fall into the category of turnarounds. In the normal course of business, multibillion-dollar enterprises such as Chrysler or Burlington Northern, DuPont or Dow Chemical, Procter and Gamble or Coca-Cola, simply cannot grow fast enough to become tenbaggers.

For a General Electric to double or triple in size in the foreseeable future is mathematically impossible. GE already has gotten so big that it represents nearly one percent of the entire U.S. gross national product. Every time you spend a dollar, GE gets almost a penny of it. Think of that. In all the trillions spent annually by American consumers, nearly a penny of every dollar goes to goods or services (light bulbs, appliances, insurance, the National Broadcasting